

1453

FALL OF CONSTANTINOPLE

In 1453, the capital of the Christian Byzantine Empire, Constantinople, fell to the Ottoman Turks. Sultan Mehmed II seized the city after his heavy cannon breached walls that had resisted sieges for a thousand years. The last Byzantine emperor, Constantine XI, died in the fighting and massacre of the Christian population. The Ottoman victory was a triumph for Islam, leaving Europe open to further Turkish attacks.



△ Troops of Sultan Mehmed II

1440

1449 At the Battle of Tumu, the Chinese Yingzong Emperor is defeated and captured by Esen Khan of the Oirat Mongols

1453 The Battle of Castillon – the last in the Hundred Years' War – ends in victory for France

1444 Portuguese slave traders bring the first shiploads of enslaved people from West Africa for sale at Lagos in the Algarve

▽ Bronze plaque from Benin



1432-1481
SULTAN MEHMED II

Mehmed II led campaigns that destroyed the Byzantine Empire and spread Ottoman rule over much of the Balkans. A cultured ruler, he patronized Italian Renaissance artists.

1440

RISE OF BENIN

The West African kingdom of Benin was founded by the Edo people of what is now southern Nigeria. Under the rule of Oba (king) Ewuare, who seized power in a violent coup in 1440, it expanded to control a substantial regional empire. Over the following century Benin's capital city was beautified with exquisite bronze plaques crafted by local metalworkers.